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Tehillim 144: Who Trains My Hands

An excerpt for LinkedIn: the introduction and Chapter One, “Who Trains My Hands” (verses 1–2). The full study booklet runs to 105 pages.

ברוך ה' צורי המלמד ידי לקרב

Aryeh Leib Thorne Toren

Tehillim 144: Who Trains My Hands

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Prepared on Wednesday, 11 November 2026 (1 Kislev 5787, the second day of Rosh Chodesh Kislev), Jerusalem, in the week of Parashas Toldos.
Not for sale. For study at the table, in the beis midrash and at home.

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A note on sources

This LinkedIn excerpt contains only the introduction, Chapter One, and Appendix A (Tehillim 144 in full). The other chapters, and the other appendices named in the introduction, are in the full 105-page booklet, not in this file.

Every Hebrew quotation in this booklet was cut directly from the text as opened on Sefaria on 11 November 2026, with vowels and cantillation removed. Verses from Tanach are given in the English of *Tanakh: The Holy Scriptures* (Jewish Publication Society, 1985), as published on Sefaria. All other translations are my own working translations, made against the Hebrew printed beside them. One clause in Rashi on verse 8 is difficult, and the chapter says so. The edition used for each text is listed in the Bibliography.

Divine Names. In English this booklet writes G-d, L-rd and Hashem. In Hebrew the Tetragrammaton and the short two-letter Name are printed as ה', and the name Elokim as אלקים. No Divine Name is printed in full.

Sources and limits. Every teaching in this booklet comes from a classical text opened for it: Tanach, the Talmud Bavli, *Midrash Tehillim*, Rashi, Radak, Ibn Ezra, the Metzudas David, the Malbim, the Rambam, *Pri Tzadik* and the Ashkenazi siddur. No secondary or web source is quoted. Some communities have a custom of saying Tehillim 144 on Motzaei Shabbos; I could not open a siddur text for it this time, so it is not discussed.

Care in speech. The psalm speaks of enemies whose mouths speak lies. This booklet keeps to the applications of the commentators, and applies their words to no living person, party or government.

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INTRODUCTION

The Verse Before Ashrei

A psalm said every day, its setting, its shape, and its threads to the week and the month

Every Jew who says Ashrei begins with the last verse of Tehillim 144. This introduction sets out when the psalm was said, how the Malbim divides it, its echoes of Tehillim 18, and its threads to Toldos and Kislev.

A psalm said every day

Most people who pray know one verse of Tehillim 144 by heart without knowing where it comes from. Three times a day, before the alphabet of praise in Tehillim 145, the siddur sets two verses: one from Tehillim 84 and the last verse of our psalm.

> אשרי יושבי ביתך עוד יהללוך סלה: אשרי העם שככה לו אשרי העם שה' אלקיו: תהלה לדוד ארוממך אלוקי המלך ואברכה שמך לעולם ועד
>
> *"Happy are those who dwell in Your house; they forever praise You. Selah" (Tehillim 84:5). "Happy the people who have it so; happy the people whose G-d is the L-rd" (Tehillim 144:15). "A song of praise. Of David. I will extol You, my G-d and king, and bless Your name forever and ever" (Tehillim 145:1).*
>
> Siddur Ashkenaz, Weekday Shacharis, Ashrei

The note printed before Ashrei in the Ashkenazi siddur on Sefaria explains why the psalm of praise is said every day, and why a verse of "happy are those" comes before it.

צריך לכוין בתהלה לדוד דא"ר אלעזר כל האומר תהלה לדוד בכל יום ג"פ מובטח לו שהוא בן העולם הבא. ויותר יכוין בפסוק פותח את ידך, שעיקר מה שקבעוהו לומר בכל יום הוא בשביל אותו פסוק, שמזכיר בו שבחו של הקב"ה שמשגיח על בריותיו ומפרנסן. ונהגו לומר קודם לכן אשרי יושבי ביתך משום דילפינן מיניה שצריך אדם לישב שעה אחת קודם שיתפלל

One must have intention in "A psalm of praise of David" (Tehillim 145), for Rabbi Elazar said: Whoever says "A psalm of praise of David" every day three times is assured that he is a son of the World to Come. And he should have special intention in the verse "You open Your hand," for the main reason it was established to be said every day is that verse, which mentions the praise of the Holy One, blessed be He, who watches over His creatures and sustains them. And the custom is to say before it "Happy are those who dwell in Your house," because we learn from it that a person must sit for a while before he prays.

Siddur Ashkenaz, Weekday Shacharis, Ashrei (introductory note)

The note explains the verse from Tehillim 84, "those who dwell in Your house": a person should sit a while before he prays. It does not explain the verse from our psalm. But the siddur places it there, and so every Jew who says Ashrei begins with the end of Tehillim 144: "Happy the people who have it so; happy the people whose G-d is the L-rd." This booklet is an attempt to learn the psalm that stands behind that verse, and to discover what "so" means.

When was it said?

The psalm is headed only "of David." The commentators set it in two different moments of David's life. Radak places it at the beginning of his reign.

לדוד. זה המזמור חברו דוד אחרי מלכו בתחילה אחר שנצח מלחמת פלשתים וניצול ממלחמת ישראל וממלחמת פלשתים

"Of David": David composed this psalm after he first became king, after he won the war against the Pelishtim and was saved from the war with Israel and from the war with the Pelishtim.

Radak on Tehillim 144:1

Ibn Ezra places it later, in a time of rest.

זה המזמור חברו כאשר הניח לו השם מכל סביביו כי כן טעם כל המזמור

He composed this psalm when Hashem gave him rest from all around him, for that is the meaning of the whole psalm.

Ibn Ezra on Tehillim 144:1

The two readings are not far apart. Radak hears in the psalm a king who has just come through two dangers, the pursuit of Shaul and the war with the Pelishtim, and who asks

for a lasting peace. Ibn Ezra hears a king who already has that peace and describes it. Both agree that the psalm moves from war to quiet: from “who trains my hands for battle” at the start to “no outcry in our streets” at the end.

The shape of the psalm

The Malbim reads the psalm as one prayer with a clear request.

> בתפלה זו יזכיר כי ה' הצילהו תמיד מאויביו בהשגחתו ורדד עמים תחתיו, והוא מבקש שיעשה לו ה' נסים גלוים וראו כל עמי הארץ וייראו מה'

In this prayer he recalls that Hashem always rescued him from his enemies by His Providence and laid peoples beneath him; and he asks that Hashem do open miracles for him, so that all the peoples of the earth will see and fear Hashem.

Malbim on Tehillim 144:1

He divides it in this way. Verses 1–2 recall how G-d has always saved David: in war and in flight, and in his rule over Israel. Verses 3–4 ask why G-d should care for man at all, who is only a breath. Verses 5–8 ask for open rescue, in a series of requests that come down step by step. Verses 9–11 promise a new song. Verses 12–15 describe the blessed people: sons, daughters, storehouses, flocks, quiet streets, and, above all, G-d among them.

These are the chapters of this booklet. Each one reads a section of the psalm with Rashi, Radak, Ibn Ezra, the Metzudas David and the Malbim, and with *Midrash Tehillim* where it speaks.

An echo of Tehillim 18

Readers of Tehillim will hear another psalm behind this one. Tehillim 18, which is also found, with small differences, as Shmuel II 22, is David’s great song “on the day the L-rd saved him from the hands of all his enemies and from the hands of Shaul.” Many of its phrases return in Tehillim 144, in a shorter and more urgent form.

> ה' סלעי ומצודתי ומפלטי אלי צורי אחסה־בו מגני וקרן־ישעי משגבי

O L-RD, my crag, my fortress, my rescuer, my G-d, my rock in whom I seek refuge, my shield, my mighty champion, my haven. (JPS)

Tehillim 18:3

> מלמד ידי למלחמה ונחתה קשת־נחושה זרועתי

who trained my hands for battle; my arms can bend a bow of bronze. (JPS)

Tehillim 18:35

> חי־ה' וברוך צורי וירום אלוקי ישעי
>
> *The L-RD lives! Blessed is my rock! Exalted be G-d, my deliverer, (JPS)*
>
> Tehillim 18:47

"My rock," "my fortress," "my shield," "who trained my hands for battle," "blessed is my rock": all of these open our psalm as well. Further on, "He bent the sky and came down" (18:10) becomes "bend Your sky and come down" (144:5), and "He reached down from on high … He drew me out of the mighty waters" (18:17) becomes "reach Your hand down from on high … save me from the mighty waters" (144:7). Tehillim 18 tells what G-d did. Tehillim 144 asks Him to do it again. Both psalms are printed in full in the appendices, with the Shmuel II version, so that the reader can follow the echoes himself.

Toldos and the hands

This booklet was prepared in the week of Parashas Toldos, 5787. The parashah turns on a contrast between voice and hands.

> ויגש יעקב אל־יצחק אביו וימשהו ויאמר הקל קול יעקב והידים ידי עשו
>
> *So Jacob drew close to his father Isaac, who felt him and wondered. "The voice is the voice of Jacob, yet the hands are the hands of Esau." (JPS)*
>
> Bereishis 27:22

Our psalm begins with hands: "who trains my hands for battle." Its central request is to be saved from those "whose mouths speak lies, and whose oaths," literally "whose right hand," "are false." It is a psalm about what hands are for and what mouths are for, and about whose hands they are. David is a man of war who says that his hands belong to G-d. Chapters One and Three return to this.

Kislev

It was also prepared on 1 Kislev 5787, the second day of Rosh Chodesh, 11 November 2026. Kislev is the month of Chanukah, when, in the words of the prayer Al HaNissim, the many were given into the hands of the few.

בימי מתתיהו בן יוחנן כהן גדול חשמונאי ובניו. כשעמדה מלכות יון הרשעה על עמך ישראל להשכיחם תורתך ולהעבירם מחקי רצונך: ואתה ברחמיך הרבים עמדת להם בעת צרתם. רבת את ריבם. דנת את דינם. נקמת את נקמתם. מסרת גבורים ביד חלשים. ורבים ביד מעטים. וטמאים ביד טהורים. ורשעים ביד צדיקים. וזדים ביד עוסקי תורתך

In the days of Mattisyahu son of Yochanan, the Kohen Gadol, the Chashmonai, and his sons, when the wicked Greek kingdom rose up against Your people Israel to make them forget Your Torah and to turn them away from the laws of Your will: You, in Your great mercy, stood by them in the time of their distress. You took up their cause, You judged their claim, You avenged their wrong. You delivered the mighty into the hands of the weak, the many into the hands of the few, the impure into the hands of the pure, the wicked into the hands of the righteous, and the wanton into the hands of those who occupy themselves with Your Torah.

Siddur Ashkenaz, Al HaNissim for Chanukah

Rabbi Tzadok HaKohen of Lublin, in *Pri Tzadik*, explains why this miracle belongs to this month.

ובחודש זה נס חנוכה שהיה שלא כדרך הטבע כלל. דנס פורים היה כמעט קרוב לטבע בעיני העולם שע"י שמלכה אסתר נהפך לבבו לטובה. אבל בחנוכה שהי' במלחמה ע"י אנשים מתי מספר. ואף אחר שנתוסף עליהם מ"מ מה נחשבו נגד חיל היונים שמלכו בכיפה אז. רק ע"י מבטח עז שהיה להכהנים כי אין מעצור לה' להושיע ברב או במעט על ידי זה נצחו מסרת גבורים ביד חלשים ורבים ביד מעטים. והי' בחודש זה כסלו שנקרא ע"ש המבטח עז שיש לישראל כי ה' יהיה בכסלך

And in this month is the miracle of Chanukah, which was entirely outside the way of nature. For the miracle of Purim was almost close to nature in the eyes of the world, since through Esther becoming queen his heart was turned for the good. But Chanukah was in a war, through a handful of men; and even after more joined them, what were they against the army of the Greeks, who then ruled the world? Only through the strong trust that the Kohanim had, "for nothing prevents Hashem from saving with many or with few" (Shmuel I 14:6), through this they won: "You delivered the mighty into the hands of the weak and the many into the hands of the few." And it was in this month, Kislev, which is named for the strong trust that Israel has: "for Hashem will be b'chislecha" (Mishlei 3:26).

Pri Tzadik, Rosh Chodesh Kislev 7

It is a month in which the request of our psalm, that victory should be seen to come from G-d and not from the strength of the hand, was answered. The companion booklet on Kislev explores the month; this booklet points to it where the psalm does.

The companion booklet on Tehillim 94 noted that *Midrash Tehillim* quotes a verse of this psalm in its reading of that one. Chapter Three gives that passage here.

CHAPTER ONE

Who Trains My Hands

Verses 1–2: the king who would not boast, the stone of Golyas, and three kinds of rescue

The psalm opens with a blessing for hands taught by G-d. This chapter reads *Midrash Tehillim* on David who said "I am not king," the Midrash on the stone that felled Golyas, the Malbim on near and far war and his three levels of rescue, and the hands of Esav.

Blessed is the L-rd, my rock

> לדוד ברוך ה' צורי המלמד ידי לקרב אצבעותי למלחמה חסדי ומצודתי משגבי ומפלטי־לי מגני ובו חסיתי הרודד עמי תחתי
>
> *Of David. Blessed is the L-RD, my rock, who trains my hands for battle, my fingers for warfare; my faithful one, my fortress, my haven and my deliverer, my shield, in whom I take shelter, who makes peoples subject to me. (JPS)*
>
> Tehillim 144:1–2

The psalm opens with a blessing, and the blessing is about hands. Before David says a word about enemies or dangers, he says that the skills by which he survived were taught to him.

Midrash Tehillim opens its reading of the psalm with a verse from Mishlei.

> בכל־דרכיך דעהו והוא יישר ארחתיך
>
> *In all your ways acknowledge Him, And He will make your paths smooth. (JPS)*
>
> Mishlei 3:6

לדוד ברוך ה' צורי וגו'. אמר שלמה (משלי ג ו) בכל דרכיך דעהו. מהו בכל דרכיך דעהו. הוי נותנו בלבך לפניך בכל דרך שאתה הולך כשם שהיה דוד עושה. היה מלך ואמר איני מלך הוא מלך והוא המליכני. וכן הוא אומר (שמואל־ב ה יב) וידע דוד כי הכינו ה' למלך על ישראל. היה גבור ואמר איני גבור. היה עשיר ואמר איני עשיר. וכן הכריז ואמר (דברי הימים־א כט יא) לך ה' הגדולה והגבורה וגו'. וכן הוא אומר (שמואל־ב ח טו) ויהי דוד עושה משפט וצדקה לכל עמו. ירד למלחמה ונצח ואמר לא מגבורתי נצחתי אלא הוא עזרני והוא הנצחני ונצחתי ויצרני להיות עושה מלחמה. וכן הוא אומר (תהלים יח לג) ה' המאזרני חיל

"Of David. Blessed is the L-rd, my rock." Shlomo said, "In all your ways acknowledge Him" (Mishlei 3:6). What is "in all your ways acknowledge Him"? Set Him in your heart before you on every road you walk, as David did. He was a king, and he said: I am not king; He is King, and He made me king, as it says, "David knew that the L-rd had established him as king over Israel" (Shmuel II 5:12). He was mighty, and he said: I am not mighty. He was rich, and he said: I am not rich. And so he proclaimed, "Yours, L-rd, are greatness and might" (Divrei HaYamim I 29:11). And so it says, "David executed true justice among all his people" (Shmuel II 8:15). He went down to war and won, and said: Not by my might did I win, but He helped me and gave me victory, and formed me to wage war, as it says, "the G-d who girded me with might" (Tehillim 18:33).

Midrash Tehillim 144

The Midrash builds a portrait of a man who has everything a man can boast of, kingship, strength, wealth and victory, and who refuses to boast of any of it. Each time David is given a gift, he says that it belongs to the Giver. The proof-text for kingship is "David knew that the L-rd had established him as king": knowing that one was established by another is the opposite of pride. The proof-text for the rest is David's blessing at the end of his life: "Yours, L-rd, are greatness and might."

The Midrash reads "in all your ways acknowledge Him" as a programme for life. It is not enough to remember G-d in the synagogue. A person must set Him before himself "on every road you walk," including the road to war, the road to the treasury and the road to the throne.

Who trains my hands

The Metzudas states the meaning simply.

המלמד ידי. כל נצחון שאני עושה במלחמה לא באה בכח ידי, כי ה' הוא המלמד ידי למלחמה

"Who trains my hands": every victory I win in war does not come by the strength of my hand, for Hashem is the One who trains my hands for war.

Metzudas David on Tehillim 144:1

The Malbim notices that the verse uses two words for war, and two parts of the body.

ברוך ה' צורי תקפי הוא מה', בין נצחון המלחמה הוא המלמד ידי לקרב שהוא המלחמה שלוחמים עם האויב מקרוב, ואצבעותי למלחמה היא המלחמה שלוחמים מרחוק ע"י חצים וקשת

"Blessed is the L-rd, my rock": my strength is from Hashem, both in the victory of war: He "trains my hands for battle (kerav)," which is war fought at close quarters with the enemy; "and my fingers for warfare," which is war fought from a distance with arrows and bow.

Malbim on Tehillim 144:1

The hand fights close up, with sword and spear. The fingers fight from far away, drawing the string of the bow. David says that he was taught both. There is no kind of war, near or far, in which he trusts in his own skill.

The Midrash asks when David learned to fight with his fingers. Its answer goes back to the day of Golyas.

אימתי למד את אצבעותי למלחמה כשהרגתי את גלית. וכן הוא אומר (שמואל־א יז מט) וישלח דוד את ידו ויקח את האבן וגו'. וכך הוא הדרך מי שהוא מכה את אדם מלפנים אינו צריך שיפול אלא מלאחריו ולמה זה נפל מלפניו. אלא מלאך הלך עם האבן והשליכו בכוונה על פניו. ולא עוד אלא כובע נחושת על ראשו והיאך טבע האבן בנחשת. אלא שהיה הקב"ה עמו

When did He train my fingers for battle? When I killed Golyas, as it says, "David put his hand into the bag; he took out a stone" (Shmuel I 17:49). The way of the world is that one who is struck from the front does not fall forward but backward; why did this one fall on his face? An angel went with the stone and threw him deliberately on his face. And more: there was a bronze helmet on his head; how did the stone sink into the bronze? Because the Holy One, blessed be He, was with him.

Midrash Tehillim 144

The Midrash sees two miracles in the stone from the shepherd's bag. A man struck in the forehead should fall backward, but Golyas fell forward, on his face. And a stone should not sink into a bronze helmet. Both things happened because the stone was guided. David's fingers threw it; G-d made it land.

David himself said as much before he threw it.

ויאמר דוד אל־הפלשתי אתה בא אלי בחרב ובחנית ובכידון ואנכי בא־אליך בשם ה' צ־באות אלקי מערכות ישראל אשר חרפת היום הזה יסגרך ה' בידי והכיתך והסרתי את־ראשך מעליך ונתתי פגר מחנה פלשתים היום הזה לעוף השמים ולחית הארץ וידעו כל־הארץ כי יש אלקים לישראל וידעו כל־הקהל הזה כי־לא בחרב ובחנית יהושיע ה' כי לה' המלחמה ונתן אתכם בידנו

David replied to the Philistine, "You come against me with sword and spear and javelin; but I come against you in the name of the L-RD of Hosts, the G-d of the ranks of Israel, whom you have defied. This very day the L-RD will deliver you into my hands. I will kill you and cut off your head; and I will give the carcasses of the Philistine camp to the birds of the sky and the beasts of the earth. All the earth shall know that there is a G-d in Israel. And this whole assembly shall know that the L-RD can give victory without sword or spear. For the battle is the L-RD's, and He will deliver you into our hands." (JPS)

Shmuel I 17:45–47

"The L-rd can give victory without sword or spear. For the battle is the L-rd's." The young shepherd spoke these words before the battle, not after. The psalm that bears his name, years later, says the same thing as a blessing: "Blessed is the L-rd … who trains my hands."

The Midrash adds that David knew nothing of war at all except what G-d taught him.

ולא הייתי יודע מלחמה אלא שמו של הקדוש ברוך הוא יהי מבורך הוא למדני. וכן שאול אומר לו (שם לז) לך וה' יהיה עמך. וכן הוא אומר (שופטים ו יב) ה' עמך גבור החיל. ואומר (תהלים קיט יב) ברוך אתה ה' למדני חוקיך. איני יודע כלום אלא את למדני. שנאמר (שם עא יז) אלקים למדתני מנעורי וגו'. (שם יח) וגם עד זקנה ושיבה אלקים אל תעזבני

I did not know war; but the Name of the Holy One, blessed be He, may it be blessed, taught me. And so Shaul said to him, "Go, and may the L-rd be with you" (Shmuel I 17:37); and so it says, "The L-rd is with you, valiant warrior" (Shoftim 6:12); and it says, "Blessed are You, O L-rd; train me in Your laws" (Tehillim 119:12). I know nothing, but You taught me, as it says, "You have let me experience it, G-d, from my youth" (Tehillim 71:17), "and even in hoary old age do not forsake me, G-d" (71:18).

Midrash Tehillim 144

The chain of verses moves from war to Torah. "Blessed are You, O L-rd; train me in Your laws." The same word, teach or train, *lamed*, serves for the hands in battle and for the heart in learning. David asks to be a student in both. The Midrash ends with old age: "even in hoary old age do not forsake me." The student never graduates.

Three kinds of rescue

The second verse lists six names for G-d's protection. The Malbim does not treat them as a heap of synonyms. He sees a ladder.

> וכן ההצלה מן האויב הוא ג"כ ע"י ה', ובאר בזה ג' מדרגות, א. בעת שאסגר מפני אויב במגדל עז, הוא חסדי ומצודתי, הוא הבעל חסד שמקבל אותי במצודה שלו ובערי מעוזו, ב. גם בעת שימצאני האויב בדרך טרם אכנס אל המצודה, הוא משגבי ומפלטי מידו אל המצודה, ג. גם בעת שלא אברח אל המצודה כלל הוא מגני מפני חצי האויב ובו חסיתי
>
> *So too rescue from the enemy is also through Hashem, and he explains three levels. First, when I shut myself in a strong tower before an enemy, He is "my faithful one and my fortress": the Master of kindness who receives me into His fortress and His strongholds. Second, even when the enemy finds me on the road before I enter the fortress, He is "my haven and my deliverer" from his hand to the fortress. Third, even when I do not flee to the fortress at all, He is "my shield" from the enemy's arrows, "in whom I take shelter."*
>
> Malbim on Tehillim 144:2

The Malbim imagines three situations of a man pursued. In the first, he has reached the fortress, and G-d is the master of the fortress who lets him in. In the second, he is caught on the road, and G-d is the One who brings him safely to the gate. In the third, he does not reach the fortress at all and must stand in the open, and G-d is his shield against the arrows. David lived all three. He sheltered in strongholds, he fled on roads, and he stood alone in the open field before Golyas.

Ibn Ezra adds a briefer distinction.

> והנה חסדי – במנוחתי. ומצודתי - בצרתי
>
> *And so "my faithful one": in my rest; "and my fortress": in my distress.*
>
> Ibn Ezra on Tehillim 144:2

"My faithful one" in rest; "my fortress" in distress. G-d is not only a refuge for bad days. He is the kindness of the good days too.

The hands of Esav

The week of this booklet is the week of Toldos, and the hands of the psalm stand beside the hands of the parashah. Yitzchak felt hands that were the hands of Esav. Esav was, in the Torah's words, "a skilful hunter, a man of the field," a man whose hands were his trade.

David too was a man of the field and a man of war. The difference the psalm draws is not between hands and no hands. It is between hands that are one's own and hands that are trained by G-d. David has the hands of a warrior, but he begins his psalm by blessing the One who trained them. The Midrash puts it in one sentence: "Not by my might did I win, but He helped me."

This is also the theme of Kislev. The few who fought in the days of the Chashmonaim did not lay down their weapons; they fought. But the victory is remembered as a miracle, and the prayer of thanks for it, Al HaNissim, speaks of what G-d did, not of what they did. The hands fought; the victory was given. Rabbi Tzadok, quoted in the introduction, says the Kohanim won through "strong trust": "nothing prevents Hashem from saving with many or with few." Those are the words of Yonasan, son of Shaul, before he climbed alone with his armour-bearer against a Philistine outpost (Shmuel I 14:6). They are the same faith David spoke before Golyas: "the L-rd can give victory without sword or spear."

For the table

1. The Midrash says David refused to boast of kingship, strength or wealth. Which of your gifts is hardest not to claim as your own?
2. The Malbim distinguishes close war and distant war. Where in your life do you fight close up, and where from far away?
3. Which of the Malbim's three rescues, fortress, road or open field, have you known?
4. David fought, and called the victory G-d's. How do you hold effort and trust together?

Appendix A. Tehillim 144 in full

Hebrew from the Sefaria Miqra text (vowels removed); English from Tanakh: The Holy Scriptures (Jewish Publication Society, 1985), via Sefaria, opened 11 November 2026, with divine names written G-d and L-rd and the Hebrew Divine Names replaced as explained in the note on sources.

1 לדוד ברוך ה' צורי המלמד ידי לקרב אצבעותי למלחמה

Of David. Blessed is the L-RD, my rock, who trains my hands for battle, my fingers for warfare;

2 חסדי ומצודתי משגבי ומפלטי־לי מגני ובו חסיתי הרודד עמי תחתי

my faithful one, my fortress, my haven and my deliverer, my shield, in whom I take shelter, who makes peoples subject to me.

3 ה' מה־אדם ותדעהו בן־אנוש ותחשבהו

O L-RD, what is man that You should care about him, mortal man, that You should think of him?

4 אדם להבל דמה ימיו כצל עובר

Man is like a breath; his days are like a passing shadow.

5 ה' הט־שמיך ותרד גע בהרים ויעשנו

O L-RD, bend Your sky and come down; touch the mountains and they will smoke.

6 ברוק ברק ותפיצם שלח חציך ותהמם

Make lightning flash and scatter them; shoot Your arrows and rout them.

7 שלח ידיך ממרום פצני והצילני ממים רבים מיד בני נכר

Reach Your hand down from on high; rescue me, save me from the mighty waters, from the hands of foreigners,

8 אשר פיהם דבר־שוא וימינם ימין שקר

whose mouths speak lies, and whose oaths are false.

9 אלקים שיר חדש אשירה לך בנבל עשור אזמרה־לך

O G-d, I will sing You a new song, sing a hymn to You with a ten-stringed harp,

10 הנותן תשועה למלכים הפוצה את־דוד עבדו מחרב רעה

to You who give victory to kings, who rescue His servant David from the deadly sword.

11 פצני והצילני מיד בני־נכר אשר פיהם דבר־שוא וימינם ימין שקר

Rescue me, save me from the hands of foreigners, whose mouths speak lies, and whose oaths are false.

12 אשר בנינו כנטעים מגדלים בנעוריהם בנותינו כזוית מחטבות תבנית היכל

For our sons are like saplings, well-tended in their youth; our daughters are like cornerstones trimmed to give shape to a palace.

13 מזוינו מלאים מפיקים מזן אל־זן צאוננו מאליפות מרבבות בחוצותינו

Our storehouses are full, supplying produce of all kinds; our flocks number thousands, even myriads, in our fields;

14 אלופינו מסבלים אין־פרץ ואין יוצאת ואין צוחה ברחבתינו

our cattle are well cared for. There is no breaching and no sortie, and no wailing in our streets.

15 אשרי העם שככה לו אשרי העם שה' אלקיו

Happy the people who have it so; happy the people whose G-d is the L-RD.

Glossary

Al HaNissim. The prayer of thanks for the miracles of Chanukah and Purim, added to the Amidah and to Grace after Meals.

Ashrei. Tehillim 145, preceded by Tehillim 84:5 and 144:15, said three times daily.

Chashmonaim. The priestly family of Mattisyahu, who led the revolt against the Greek kingdom.

Chinuch. Training, education; from the same root as Chanukah, dedication.

Hevel. Breath, vapour; the word of Koheles, "futility."

Ibn Ezra. Rabbi Avraham ibn Ezra (1089–1167), grammarian, poet and commentator.

Malbim. Rabbi Meir Leibush Weiser (1809–1879), commentator on all of Tanach.

Metzudas David. Commentary by Rabbi David Altschuler and his son Rabbi Yechiel Hillel (eighteenth century).

Midrash Tehillim. The classical midrash on Tehillim, also called Shocher Tov.

Nevel asor. The ten-stringed harp (Tehillim 144:9).

Pri Tzadik. Discourses on the Torah and the festivals by Rabbi Tzadok HaKohen of Lublin (1823–1900).

Radak. Rabbi David Kimchi (1160–1235), grammarian and commentator, of Narbonne.

Rashi. Rabbi Shlomo Yitzchaki (1040–1105), the foremost commentator on Tanach and Talmud.

Sela HaMachlekos. The Rock of Separation, where Shaul turned back from pursuing David (Shmuel I 23:28).

Sheminis. The "eighth," a musical term in the headings of Tehillim 6 and 12.

Zavis. Corner; the corner pillars of Tehillim 144:12.

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All glory to the Ribono shel Olam · Errors are mine

Aryeh Leib Thorne Toren